

After Thatcher got elected in 1979 and the subsequent Big Bang reforms, the city was thought of as being the icon of achievement in the U.K. If you were a AAA student, that is where you would end up. I was expecting to meet all these smart people. My list of companies included a lot of highly regarded financial firms. What both fascinated and appalled me was here were all these people just out of university, making hundreds of thousands of pounds, while I'm making £12,000, and I thought 99 percent of them were just plain stupid. They were thick and arrogant, and yet they were all earning these staggering sums of money. I had an epiphany. I thought, *Hang on; it can't be all that difficult to make money if all these idiots are doing it.*

As an accounting student, if you interview a trader for an audit, they try to blind you with jargon. They hit you with lots of alphas, deltas, gammas, blah, blah, blah, in the hope you'll run away in 10 minutes because you can't understand anything they say. I hate failure, though, so I would make them take me through it. By doing that, I became fascinated by how markets work. Also, the 1 percent of traders who were smart were *really* smart. I've always loved politics and economics, and I enjoyed seeing how they impacted markets. And, on top of that, I realized I could actually make a lot of money by being a trader. I went from not being interested in the stock market at all to being fascinated by it.

I've always been quite tight and interested in saving my money. At the time, I was saving money to put down as a deposit on a house. It seems bizarre now, but I used that money to start trading options on the FTSE.

You started trading without any prior knowledge at all?

None whatsoever. At this stage, I had been reading the *Financial Times* every day for about 18 months. I also had been reading books on markets and traders, including your books.

Any books that were influential?

Actually, your books were very influential. I still reread them now and then.

Why did you decide to trade options on the FTSE index instead of trading stocks?